

Stephen Michalak Close Encounter with UFO at Falcon Lake

At 12:15 p.m. on May 19, 1967, Stephen Michalak, who was engaged in some amateur prospecting near Falcon Lake, on the Manitoba/Ontario border, was startled to see two cigar-shaped objects with "bumps" on them, glowing red and descending. One object stopped in mid-air, hovered, and then silently rose and disappeared into the clouds. The other object, about thirty-five feet in diameter and twelve feet high, landed about 160 feet away from Michalak. A door opened in the side of the craft and Michalak heard voices within. He called out in English and Russian, but got no response. He was able to walk up to the craft and actually touch it, but it took off as he stood near it, burning his chest and setting his shirt on fire. He went to a doctor, who found a pattern of burn marks in a grid on his chest. He suffered from nausea, vomiting, diarrhea, weight loss, and a drop in lymphocyte count. Investigators found unusual levels of Radium 226 at the landing site.



Photographs of Stephen Michalak showing geometric pattern burned onto his body by the exhaust gases of an alleged UFO. Mr. Michalak's burns were treated but continued to re-appear for many years after his encounter with a mysterious craft in the Canadian wilderness.

THE EVENTS AT FALCON LAKE, 1967

During Victoria Day week-end, Canadian Stephen Michalak of Winnipeg, a mechanic by trade, decided to do some prospecting in the Whiteshell Provincial Park. Michalak was an amateur geologist and had been prospecting in the area many times. Others had found several quartz veins near Falcon Lake that were associated with silver deposits, and Michalak had himself found a few promising sites. So, on May 19, 1967, he traveled from Winnipeg to Falcon Lake, where he spent the night in a motel on the Trans-Canada Highway.

Michalak left his motel at 5:30 that morning and headed north into the wilds of the park. At about 9:00 a.m. he found a quartz vein near a small stream. At 11:00 a.m. he ate lunch, then continued to examine the quartz formation. At 12:15 p.m. Michalak's concentration was disturbed by the cackling of some geese. He looked up and was surprised to see two red, glowing cigar-shaped objects descending at a forty-five degree angle. As they came nearer, their appearance became more oval and then disc-shaped.

As he watched, one of the objects stopped and hovered, while the other one descended and landed on a large, flat rock about 160 feet away from him. After a few moments the object still in the air departed, changing from red to orange to grey as it flew into the west and disappeared behind the clouds. The object on the ground also turned from red to grey and finally to the color of "hot stainless steel" surrounded by a golden-hued glow. He had been wearing welding goggles while chipping at the quartz to protect his eyes from flying rock fragments, and now they served the additional purpose of protecting his eyes from a brilliant purple light that was shining through openings in the object's exterior. The object was making a hissing sound and a whirring noise, and it gave off a sulphurous smell.



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Drawing by Steven Michalak

For several minutes, Michalak stayed where he was and sketched the object. After about half an hour, a door opened in the side of the object, revealing a lighted interior. Michalak decided to move closer, and when he was approximately sixty feet away from the object, he began to hear two voices over the other sounds coming from the object.

Believing that the object was a secret experimental American craft of some sort, Michalak called out in English. There was no response, so he tried Russian, German, Italian, French, Ukrainian, and then English again. There was still no response.

Summoning his nerve, Michalak approached the open door and stuck his head inside. There he saw a maze of lights on what appeared to be a panel, and beams of light in horizontal and diagonal patterns. There was also a cluster of lights flashing in a random sequence "like on a computer."

Not seeing anyone, he pulled back and waited. Suddenly, three panels slid together, closing the opening completely. Michalak then examined the outer surface of the object, noting that it was like highly polished colored glass with no breaks or seams in its surface. He touched it, and it melted his glove.

Without warning, the object moved, and something like an exhaust vent was now in front of him. It was about nine inches high by six inches wide, and contained a uniform pattern of round holes, each about 1/16 inch in diameter. A blast of hot gas shot from these holes onto his chest, setting his shirt and undershirt on fire and causing him severe pain. He tore off his burning garments and threw them to the ground. He looked up in time to see the craft depart like the first, and felt a rush of air as it ascended.

After the object was gone, Michalak noticed a strong odor of burning electrical insulation along with the sulphurous smell he had noticed earlier. Some moss on the ground had been set on fire by his burning shirts, and so he stamped it out.

The spot where the object had landed looked as if it had been swept clean, but piled up in a 15 foot circle was a collection of pine needles, dirt and leaves. As he looked around, he developed a severe headache, became nauseous, and broke out in a cold sweat. His nausea became worse, and he soon vomited. He decided to head back to the motel, and on the way back he had to stop several times because of vomiting.

Finally, after asking for help from a passing RCMP officer and being refused, he reached the motel. At 4:00 p.m., he entered the coffee shop and asked where he could find a doctor. He was told that the nearest doctor was in Kenora, Ontario, 45 miles east of Falcon Lake. Michalak decided to return to Winnipeg rather than go into Ontario.

The next bus to Winnipeg didn't come through until around 8:45 p.m., so he went to his room and called his wife. He told her not to worry, but that he had had an accident and to send their son to meet him at the bus terminal. He got to Winnipeg at around 10:15 p.m., and his son immediately took him to the Misericordia Hospital, where his headache and nausea were treated and the curious burn marks on his chest in the shape of a grid were noted.

One of the RCMP investigators tried to make the case that Michalak had burned his chest on a barbecue grill. However, the burn pattern was opposite to what it would have been had that been the case. There was a manned firetower nearby, but the lookouts reportedly saw nothing that day. Michalak never made any money off his experience. In fact, he had to pay all of his own medical expenses, including a trip to the Mayo Clinic on Minnesota. A small, privately published booklet he wrote on the experience lost money.

Over the course of the next two years, Michalak was examined by more than one dozen physicians in the United States and Canada. Site investigations were made by members of the RCMP, RCAF, government officials and numerous civilians. Among those who traveled back to the site with Michalak were representatives of: the RCAF (Royal Canadian Air Force) Training Command Headquarters, CFB (Canadian Forces Base) Winnipeg, RCMP CID (Criminal Investigations Division); the federal Department of Health and Welfare, and the Manitoba provincial Department of Health and Welfare. Also, the University of Colorado Condon Committee investigated the case, Life magazine reporters came to Manitoba and two civilian UFO groups, APRO (Aerial Phenomena Research Organization) and CAPRO (Canadian APRO), became involved. Finally, the federal Department of Mines and Natural Resources got involved to a degree, as did the Whiteshell Nuclear Research Establishment (WNRE), the Manitoba Cancer Institute, the Mayo Clinic, and a host of other medical establishments.

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INSOLUBLE MISERIES

An article by the renowned Canadian UFO researcher Chris Rutkowski.

By now, many of you will have seen my appearance as a "U.F.O. Researcher" on the Unsolved Mysteries segment aired on November 4th, 1992. The segment concerned the strange story of Stefan Michalak, who claimed he was injured by an encounter with a saucer-shaped craft in May, 1967.

Long ignored by most ufologists, the case may very well be one of the best on record. According to his story, Michalak was doing some amateur prospecting near the resort town of Falcon Lake, Manitoba, Canada, examining the many rock outcroppings for signs of quartz. The area is part of the Canadian Shield, quite rugged and covered with evergreens. Numerous lakes and swamps exist there, and the forests are protected by Federal and Provincial programs.

Around noon, Michalak heard the sounds of agitated geese on a pond below his perch on a rocky plateau. He looked up to see two red cigar-shaped objects flying slowly through the sky. One descended toward him, and appeared to land about 150 feet away in a clearing. After it landed, it appeared to change colour from red to orange to silver, as it "cooled down". It was now a classic flying saucer, about 35-40 feet in diameter, with a dome on its upper surface. The other object in the sky flew away.

Over the next hour, Michalak observed the object from a hiding spot behind a large rock formation. He sketched the object and puzzled over its nature. He couldn't see any markings on the side, and he didn't believe in "little green men" at the time. He concluded it was an experimental American aircraft which had landed for repairs. His theory seemed correct when he heard some high-pitched voices coming from the craft. A door opened in its side, and brilliant purple lights flooded out of the portal.

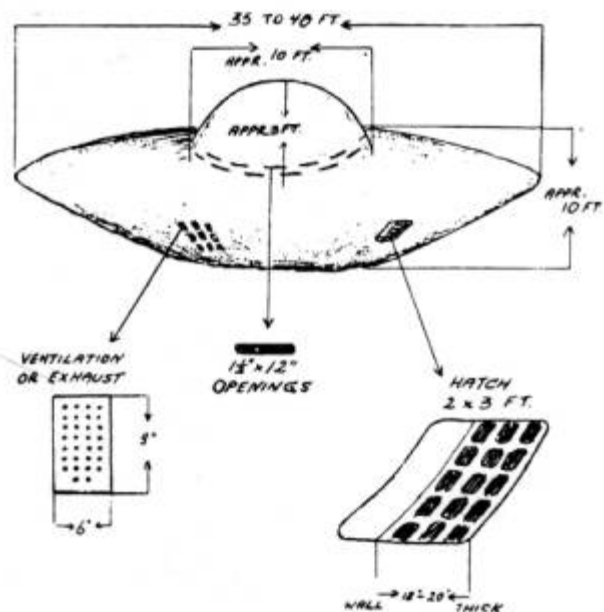
He decided to sarcastically ask the Americans if they needed help fixing their ship, so he cautiously walked toward the vehicle and shouted his offer for assistance. The voices ceased abruptly. Edging closer, he reached the side of the craft and poked his head into the opening. He noticed that its walls were about eight inches thick, and had a honeycombed appearance. Inside the ship, he could see what he described as a myriad of small flashing lights, like those on a computer panel. Stepping back, he found that when he touched the side of the craft with his rubberized work glove, the glove had melted from intense heat.

Suddenly, the door closed and the craft rotated counterclockwise. In front of him was some sort of "exhaust" grille. A blast of hot gas shot out of the grille, striking him in the chest and knocking him on his back. His shirt was set on fire, and he struggled to remove it. The craft quickly ascended and flew out of sight.

As the Unsolved Mysteries segment showed, a dazed Michalak staggered back to civilization with his fantastic story. The story of the investigation is itself a fantastic tale. Michalak was beleaguered by reporters, UFO buffs, loonies and other characters all wanting the REAL story or to give him their own advice on how to deal with the aliens.

Much has been published about the Michalak case, some of it inaccurate and contrived. An excellent series of articles had appeared in Canadian UFO Report in the late 1960's and early 1970's, but it did not receive much attention outside of Canada. After I had reopened the case files in the late 1970's, I wrote a series of articles about it for FLYING SAUCER REVIEW, whose editors were astounded that a full report on the case had never seen international print before.

Yet, I have found the Michalak case recounted in various versions in many books and zines, often repeating claims of radiation sickness and alien death rays.



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I had re-opened the case because the original team of investigators had broken up, and the case files were unavailable. I re-interviewed Michalak and his family, and tracked down several hundred pages of government documents about the case. Dr. Berthold Schwarz was invaluable in his assistance in tracking down much of the information, especially the medical reports.

The case had been investigated by the RCMP, RCAF, USAF and Edward Condon's Colorado UFO Project (which listed it as "Case 22": unexplained). The incident had been debated several times in the Canadian House of Commons because the public wanted to know what the government had learned about the injury to a Canadian citizen. An official announcement was made that the files would never be made public because of a danger to "the public interest".

This, of course, fueled the belief that the craft had been an alien spaceship. The government was obviously covering up the affair, and the whole thing smacked of conspiracy. It didn't help when a UFO buff asked the Mayo Clinic for Michalak's medical records, and the response was that Michalak had never been there. Of course, Michalak had the bills to prove his stay there had been real.

Another often-repeated story is that Michalak had some sort of radiation sickness or had radiation burns. This isn't supported by the medical reports. If the pattern of burns on his abdomen was caused by radiation, he would have had many other symptoms of this. The pattern was considered by dermatologists to have been caused by chemicals, more like an actual exhaust such as Michalak had described. Another story in circulation (particularly in the four-volume set of UFO books by Yves Naud) is that Michalak was suffering from impurities in his blood, brought on by the UFO's radiative effects. Again, this is not supported by the medical evidence. In fact, it is often repeated that Michalak lost a great deal of weight and that his lymphocyte count was reduced, more symptoms of radiation poisoning. The trouble is that Michalak had not been to a doctor for many months before his experience, and there were no records of his pre-experience weight or blood count available for comparison. Michalak believed that he had lost weight the same way we all think we might have lost weight - he guessed and looked at his own bathroom scale. Considering he had severe nausea and vomiting, this wouldn't be too unusual. As a matter of fact, this is more evidence in support of his having ingested a chemical mixture of gases.

Still, we're left with a curious case. Physiological and physical effects, an unchanging story over 25 years, and yet there are no definite answers to what happened to Michalak at Falcon Lake in 1967. If it was a hoax (and psychological testing suggests that Michalak didn't do it), then it is certainly one of the best on record. Why would a hoaxer physically harm himself and put up with 25 years of ridicule by making up a saucer story? Publicity? No. The Michalaks shy away from publicity. Money? No. The Michalaks haven't made a bankroll from the experience, as some might claim. Notoriety? No. In fact, the Michalaks have threatened to take action against some people mentioning the case in public because they just want to be left alone.

OBITUARY: STEFAN MICHALAK

by Chris Rutkowski
30th October 1999

It is with great sadness that I report the passing of Stefan Michalak, last week, at age 83.

Michalak was known to ufologists as the witness in one of the most puzzling and well-documented CE2 cases on record. His close encounter with an unidentified craft in the Canadian wilderness in 1967 left him physically scarred. Medical examinations by Canadian and American physicians could not offer a definitive explanation of his wounds and aftereffects.

Until recently, despite the incredible amount of evidence in support of his claimed experience, there were no explanations offered by skeptics regarding "what really happened." Only two published works have dealt with the case in any detail, offering two greatly contrasting explanations. One skeptic simply noted Michalak must have been a hoaxer, without addressing any of the case's major details, while the other implied that Michalak must have been the victim of a secret aerospace experiment. Neither explanation was satisfactory.

I first met Michalak as a youth, when one of my playmates told me his father had been burned by a flying saucer. At the time, I was more interested in riding my bicycle and playing baseball with my school friends than I was in my friend's father laying sick in his bed. When I reached university and began reading about UFOs and other scientific controversies, I realized that no comprehensive study had ever been done on

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what I believed to be the most significant UFO case in North America. I re-established contact with my childhood friend and his family, and spent many hours talking with them about their shared experience. I say shared experience, because Michalak's entire family was affected by what had occurred. They spoke bitterly about their treatment at the hands of both media and investigators, and understandably wished that the world would simply leave them alone. However, Michalak himself stubbornly refused to give in to pressure, and boldly and tirelessly told visitors and callers about his experience. More significantly, he did not alter the details of his story with each telling, and he did not believe he had seen a craft from another world. He said, realistically, that he did not know what the object had been.

When Michalak went to the Mayo clinic following his experience, he went as an outpatient, since Canadian medical insurance would not cover his expenses. But he, himself, wanted to know what was wrong with him. One can ask, logically, why an alleged hoaxer would go to such trouble and expense. Regardless, however, the psychiatric assessment of Michalak proved to be most interesting; the examining physician found Michalak to be an exceptionally stable and well-adjusted individual, with no psychopathology or indication he was prone to making up stories.

I remember one incident very well which indicates Michalak's character. When NBC flew his family and myself to the set of Unsolved Mysteries, I had opportunity to spend many hours with his family. We talked about many things, and I became further convinced that his family was as mystified by his experience as anyone else. But the most telling event took place while they were filming him for the program.

Just before rolling film, the director wanted Michalak to relax and feel more comfortable in front of the cameras. He began talking with him about the weather, his work, what Canada was like and other nonchalant topics. Then, the director said, "Well, Steve, I guess your being burned by the UFO was the most incredible thing that has ever happened in your life." To the surprise of everyone on the set, Michalak answered, "Oh, no, it wasn't." Prodded further, Michalak bravely told the story of his experiences in the Nazi death camps, speaking bluntly and unwaveringly about the atrocities he witnessed firsthand. No one dared interrupt his story, and when he was finished, the set was filled with a stunned silence; the entire crew was awestruck. Later, one of the crew said to me, "This guy is the most credible we've ever interviewed. What's being burned by a flying saucer compared with Nazi ovens?" From that moment on, Michalak was treated with much respect and dignity, justly deserved. The questioning regarding the UFO turned from "Did it really happen?" to "What happened?"

I don't know what transpired that spring afternoon in the Canadian Shield. I know what Michalak told me, and I know that he was not type of person to make up tall tales. I believe all investigating bodies were truly puzzled by the case, and desperately grasped for straws that would answer some of the questions. Michalak alone knew, and we may never have all our questions answered.

I offer condolences to his family, not only from myself but from the entire ufological community. I was honoured to know Stefan Michalak, and he will be missed.

Chris Rutkowski, 30 October 1999.

www.chez.com/lesovnis/htm/michalak67.htm